

“Vers l’Infini(tif) et Au-delà », Identifying Finiteness in Creoles: A Contrastive Study of the Complementation Systems of Martinican Creole and Haitian Creole.

Finiteness, and its multifaceted features stemming from morphology, syntax, semantics, and pragmatics, presents unique challenges in the study of Creole languages. The latter, due to their isolating characteristics, challenge conventional linguistic typologies of finiteness therefore making them pivotal for comparative generative syntax. Indeed, the absence of traditional morphological inflections in isolating languages raises important questions about the legitimacy of a finite/nonfinite distinction for Creole languages, akin to debates in other isolating languages like Mandarin Chinese. By examining the behavior of Tense, Mood, and Aspect (TMA) markers, subject agreement/licensing (i.e. obviation, coreference), and negation scope/licensing in complement clauses, this study provides a comparative analysis of Martinican Creole (MC) and Haitian Creole (HC) to determine how applicable and relevant the concept of finiteness is to isolating languages like MC and HC.

This work explores the evolution of the complementation systems of MC and HC separately over a 40-year period (i.e. diachronically and intra-linguistically) and compares them with each other as they are attested nowadays (i.e. synchronically and inter-linguistically) by using data from my HC and MC corpora, and native speaker acceptability judgments. Additionally, I use a previously established framework (Bianchi 2003, Landau 2004, Adger 2007, Nikolaeva 2007, 2010; Wurmbrand 2014, 2015) to describe these systems in terms of their syntactic/semantic finite nature as well as the size of their syntactic projections. I examine causative verb HC/MC *fè* ‘make’, volitional verb HC *vle* and MC *lé* ‘want’, modals HC *ka/dwe* and HC *pé/dwet* ‘must/can’, raising verb HC *sanble* and MC *sanm* ‘seem’, and the impersonal expression HC/MC *fok* ‘one must’. These predicates host complement clauses with each their own syntactic properties with regards to subject licensing, temporal specification, the licensing of the HC/MC zero-marker, and the licensing of negation (as summarized in Figure 1). Diachronically, we observe featural differences for these predicates, some of which might be attributable to language contact. Synchronically, these predicates show properties that, at times, make MC and HC more similar to each other than previously claimed (e.g. with causative verbs), but at other times they appear more different from each other than expected (e.g. with modals).

In conclusion, the study shows that Creole languages, despite having little inflectional morphology, do in fact have clauses that should be considered finite and others nonfinite. Moreover, I show that finer-grained distinctions can be made based on the size of these complement clauses and that they compare cross-linguistically to languages outside of the Creole family.

References:

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Overview of Findings:

Finite complement clauses					
Predicate types	Subject Type	Temporal Specification	Zero-marker Licensing	Negation Type	Complement Type
Make	Free	Independent	Yes	Sentential	Indicative
Seem	Free	Independent	Yes	Sentential	
Fok	Free	Future-oriented	No	Sentential	Subjunctive
Want	Free	Future-oriented	No	Sentential	

Nonfinite complement clauses					
Want	Non-coreferential	Future-oriented	No	vP	Partial control
Seem	Anaphorical	Dependent	No	vP	Raising
Epistemic Modals	Anaphorical	Dependent	No	vP	Raising
Deontic Modals	Anaphorical	Anaphorical	No	vP	Exhaustive control
Make	Non-coreferential	Anaphorical	No	vP	

Figure 1 – Description of the complementation systems of MC and HC

Note: The findings summarized in this figure suggest that the main properties that are absent in nonfinite complement clauses in HC and MC are 1) the free subject type, 2) the ability to license sentential negation, 3) the independent temporal specification on the complement clause and 4) its ability to license the zero-marker.